

COVER TO COVER

AMOS & HOSEA

Teaching Notes

Amos (c. 760 BC)

- Preached primarily to the Northern Kingdom.
- Warned that injustice and idolatry would bring destruction.
- **Written about 35–40 years before Assyria conquered Israel.**

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:

Can two walk together, except they be agreed Amos 3:3

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK:

- 1) Judgement of Surrounding Nations — 1:1 — 2:3
- 2) Judgment of Judah and Israel — 2:4 — 6:14
- 3) Visions of the Future — Chapters 7-9

JUDGMENTS OF SURROUNDING NATIONS:

- Judgment against Syria for cruelty – 1: 3–5
- Judgment against PHILISTIA for selling Israelites into slavery in Edom– 1:6–8
- Judgment against PHOENICIA for breaking their covenant with Israel – 1:9–10
- Judgment against Edom for causing Israel to suffer– 1:11–12
- Judgment against AMMON for violence against Israel – 1: 13–15
- Judgment against Moab for injustice – 2:1–3

JUDGEMENT OF JUDAH AND ISRAEL:2:4–6:14

- Judgment against Judah for despising the law – 2:4–5
- Judgment against Israel for immorality – 2:6–16
- God’s charge against the whole house of Israel – the 12 tribes – 3:1–6: 14

VISIONS OF THE FUTURE: CHAPTERS 7-9

- Visions of the grasshoppers – 7:1–3
- Visions of the fire – 7:4–6
- Visions of the plum line – 7:7–17

- Visions of basket of summer fruit – chapter 8
- Vision of the Lord at the altar – 9:1–10
- Future Kingdom and David’s Tabernacle – 9: 11–15.

Amos was not a professional prophet, priest, or member of a prophetic school. He was a shepherd and a cultivator of sycamore-fig trees whom God unexpectedly called to deliver one of the strongest messages of justice and covenant accountability in the Old Testament.

Understanding Amos: When Worship and Life No Longer Agree

The book of Amos becomes much more powerful when we understand **what Israel looked like when Amos arrived**. Amos wasn't preaching to a nation that appeared to be falling apart. In many ways, **Israel looked successful**.

That is what makes Amos so sobering.

1. What was happening when Amos began preaching?

The Historical Setting

Amos ministered during the reigns of:

- **Uzziah**, king of Judah (Southern Kingdom)
- **Jeroboam II**, king of Israel (Northern Kingdom)

His ministry is usually dated around **760–755 BC**, making him a contemporary of **Jonah**, with **Hosea** and **Isaiah beginning** their ministries shortly afterward.

Amos prophesied around **760 BC**, during the reign of **Jeroboam II**, king of the Northern Kingdom of Israel (Amos 1:1; 2 Kings 14:23–29).

This was roughly **38 years before Samaria fell to Assyria in 722 BC**.

But here's what Israel did not realize:

They were living in the final decades of their nation, and they didn't know it.

Jeroboam II's reign was a period of territorial expansion and prosperity. Israel had regained territory, commerce was thriving, and wealthy people were enjoying increasingly luxurious lifestyles.

They could have looked around and thought:

"God must be blessing us. Look how well we're doing."

But Amos essentially walked into their prosperity and announced:

"What you see on the outside is not an accurate picture of what God sees on the inside."

Their economy was healthy.

Their religious services were active.

Their houses were beautiful.

Their nation appeared secure.

But spiritually, they were dying.

That makes Amos incredibly relevant. **Prosperity is not always proof of God's approval.**

2. Amos Was an Unlikely Prophet

One of the most relatable things about Amos is **who he was**.

Amos wasn't part of Israel's religious establishment. He came from **Tekoa in Judah**, south of Jerusalem, and described himself as a shepherd/herdsman and someone who tended sycamore figs (Amos 1:1; 7:14–15).

A Shepherd Called by God

Amos introduces himself simply:

"I was among the shepherds of Tekoa."

Tekoa was a small town approximately ten miles south of Jerusalem.

Research shows the Hebrew word translated "shepherd" likely refers to someone who raised a special breed of sheep prized for their wool. Amos also cared for sycamore-fig trees, which required cutting or piercing the fruit so it would ripen properly.

Look at the symbolism here:

Before Amos ever diagnosed the spiritual sickness of a nation, he spent years caring for sheep and cultivating fruit.

Then God essentially said:

"Go north. I have something I want you to say to Israel."

Imagine the situation.

A man from the **Southern Kingdom** walks into the prosperous **Northern Kingdom** and begins telling them that judgment is coming.

He doesn't have the religious credentials they would have expected.

He isn't part of their prophetic circles.

He isn't from their kingdom.

And yet **he has heard from God.**

When Amaziah the priest eventually tells Amos to leave and go back to Judah, Amos' response is powerful:

"I was no prophet... but I was an herdsman... And the LORD took me as I followed the flock, and the LORD said unto me, Go, prophesy unto my people Israel."
— Amos 7:14–15

In other words:

"I didn't choose this assignment. God chose me for it."

3. Israel's Problem Wasn't That They Had Stopped Worshiping

This is extremely important.

Israel was still worshiping.

They had religious gatherings.

They offered sacrifices.

They sang worship songs.

They observed religious festivals.

But God says something shocking:

"I hate, I despise your feast days..."

— Amos 5:21

And then:

"Take thou away from me the noise of thy songs..."

— Amos 5:23

Why would God reject worship offered to Him?

Because **their worship and their lives contradicted each other.**

They could lift their hands to God and then mistreat people made in God's image.

They could bring offerings and then exploit the poor.

They could participate in worship while tolerating sexual immorality.

They wanted God's **blessing** without God's **government**.

God wasn't merely looking for songs. He wanted lives that agreed with the songs.

That helps us understand one of the central ideas you listed.

"Can two walk together, except they be agreed?" — Amos 3:3

Think about **walking with God** literally.

If God is walking toward righteousness and I am walking toward compromise, eventually we aren't walking together anymore.

If God says, **"This matters to Me,"** and I continually say, **"It doesn't matter to me,"** we aren't in agreement.

Amos is confronting a nation that believed:

"We belong to God, so we're safe."

God responds:

"If you belong to Me, then your life should agree with Me."

In fact, their covenant relationship with God made them **more accountable**, not less:

"You only have I known of all the families of the earth: therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities."

— Amos 3:2

Privilege created responsibility.

4. Amos Begins With the Nations Around Israel

Amos 1:3–2:3

This is brilliant.

Amos doesn't immediately begin by condemning Israel.

He starts talking about **everybody else**.

He pronounces judgment on:

Syria/Damascus — for extreme cruelty.

Philistia/Gaza — for capturing whole communities and selling people into slavery.

Phoenicia/Tyre — for participating in slave trading and breaking covenant commitments.

Edom — for relentlessly pursuing his "brother" with violence.

Ammon — for horrific wartime brutality.

Moab — for desecration and vengeance.

You can almost imagine the Israelites listening:

"Amen, Amos!"

"Tell Syria!"

"Tell those Philistines!"

"God needs to judge these wicked nations!"

And then Amos turns the sermon toward **Judah**.

And finally...

Israel.

Suddenly nobody is shouting "Amen."

It's as though Amos drew a circle around Israel that became smaller and smaller until **Israel was standing in the middle of it.**

The message is:

"God sees the sins of the nations—but He also sees yours."

5. Then Amos Turns Toward Judah

Amos 2:4–5

Judah's sin was different.

God says they had:

"despised the law of the LORD."

Judah possessed God's revealed Word but refused to live according to it.

There is an important principle here:

The greater the revelation, the greater the responsibility.

The pagan nations were judged for terrible acts of cruelty and injustice.

But Judah had something those nations didn't have:

God's Torah.

They knew better.

6. Finally, Amos Comes for Israel

Amos 2:6–6:14

This is the heart of Amos' message.

Israel's sin involved **idolatry, sexual immorality, greed, injustice and exploitation of vulnerable people.**

Amos 2:6 says:

"They sold the righteous for silver, and the poor for a pair of shoes."

Imagine becoming so consumed with money that **a human life becomes less important than personal profit.**

The wealthy were living comfortably while the poor were being crushed.

Amos describes people lying on luxurious beds and eating the finest foods while remaining unmoved by the spiritual destruction happening around them (Amos 6:4–6).

That may be one of Amos' most frightening pictures.

They had become comfortable with what broke God's heart.

Their greatest danger wasn't simply their sin.

They had stopped being disturbed by it.

7. God Had Warned Them Repeatedly

Amos 4 contains a heartbreaking repeated statement.

God reminds Israel of various disasters and hardships He had allowed, and repeatedly says:

"Yet have ye not returned unto me."

That phrase keeps appearing.

"Yet you did not return to Me."

God wasn't sending judgment because He wanted to destroy them.

He had been trying to get their attention.

The famine should have awakened them.

The drought should have awakened them.

The agricultural devastation should have awakened them.

The military defeats should have awakened them.

But every warning was ignored.

And finally comes the terrifying statement:

"Prepare to meet thy God, O Israel."

— Amos 4:12

The God they refused to meet through **repentance** they would eventually meet through **judgment**.

8. "Seek Me and Live"

Yet Amos isn't simply a book of doom.

Right in the middle of the warnings, God's heart comes through:

"Seek ye me, and ye shall live."

— Amos 5:4

And again:

"Seek the LORD, and ye shall live."

— Amos 5:6

That's the heart behind Amos.

God is essentially saying:

"Come back to Me before what I have warned you about happens."

There was still time.

Assyria hadn't conquered them yet.

Samaria hadn't fallen yet.

The people hadn't been carried away yet.

The warning itself was mercy.

God sent Amos approximately four decades before the final destruction.

Think about that.

God warned them for a generation before judgment finally came.

9. Then Amos Sees Five Powerful Visions

Chapters 7–9 move from Amos **preaching** about judgment to Amos **seeing** what was coming.

Vision #1 — The Locusts/Grasshoppers

Amos 7:1–3

Amos sees locusts devouring Israel's crops.

This could have been economically devastating.

And Amos does something beautiful:

He intercedes.

"O Lord GOD, forgive, I beseech thee: by whom shall Jacob arise? for he is small."

God relents concerning this particular judgment.

Notice Amos' heart:

A true prophet doesn't enjoy announcing judgment. He intercedes for the people receiving the warning.

Vision #2 — The Devouring Fire

Amos 7:4–6

Amos then sees a consuming fire.

Again Amos cries out:

"O Lord GOD, cease, I beseech thee."

And again God relents.

Twice Amos stands between judgment and the people.

But then something changes.

Vision #3 — The Plumb Line

Amos 7:7–9

This is one of the greatest images in Amos.

A **plumb line** was used by builders to determine whether a wall was truly vertical.

You don't argue with a plumb line.

You hold it beside the wall and discover whether the wall is straight or crooked.

God essentially says:

"I'm putting My standard beside Israel."

Israel had been measuring themselves against the surrounding nations.

They probably looked pretty good compared with some of them.

But God doesn't measure us by comparing us with everybody around us.

God measures us against His standard.

And when God's plumb line was placed beside Israel...

the wall was crooked.

This time Amos doesn't intercede.

The measurement has been made.

Vision #4 — The Basket of Summer Fruit

Amos 8

This sounds pleasant until you understand the picture.

Summer fruit was **ripe fruit**.

Once fruit becomes completely ripe, there isn't much time left before it spoils.

God tells Amos:

"The end is come upon my people of Israel."

— Amos 8:2

Israel wasn't merely becoming ripe.

They were fully ripe for judgment.

The time for warning was rapidly disappearing.

Vision #5 — The Lord Standing at the Altar

Amos 9:1–10

Finally Amos sees the Lord standing at the altar.

This is significant because the altar should have represented **worship, sacrifice and meeting with God.**

But now judgment begins there.

Their religious system couldn't protect them from the God they had refused to obey.

They couldn't hide behind:

"But we worship God."

God had already addressed that.

Worship without obedience had become empty religion.

10. And Then Comes Hope: David's Fallen Tabernacle

If Amos ended at Amos 9:10, it would be devastating.

But God isn't finished.

Suddenly the entire tone changes.

"In that day will I raise up the tabernacle of David that is fallen..."

— Amos 9:11

Judgment would come.

Israel would fall.

The Northern Kingdom would eventually be conquered by Assyria.

But **God's covenant purposes would not fail.**

Amos looks beyond Israel's destruction toward a future restoration connected with **David's house and kingdom.**

And this becomes especially important in the New Testament.

In **Acts 15:13–18**, James quotes Amos 9:11–12 when explaining God's work among the Gentiles.

So Amos begins with nations being judged...

but ends with nations being included in God's redemptive purposes.

Judgment isn't the last word. Restoration is.

The Emotional Heart of Amos

If I were teaching Amos to a class, I would summarize the entire book this way:

Israel thought they were safe because they were prosperous, religious and God's chosen people. Amos came to tell them that God was not measuring their bank accounts, buildings, worship services or national success. He was measuring their hearts.

And the tragedy is that **they still had time to change.**

God warned them.

God corrected them.

God sent prophets.

God disrupted their comfort.

God repeatedly invited them:

"Seek Me and live."

But they would not return.

About 35–40 years later, the Assyrian army arrived.

Samaria fell in **722 BC.**

The Northern Kingdom was carried into exile.

And suddenly the words of a shepherd from Tekoa didn't sound extreme anymore.

They sounded prophetic.

The lesson of Amos

Never mistake God's patience for God's approval.

And never mistake outward prosperity for inward health.

God still asks:

Does your worship agree with your life?

Does your treatment of people agree with your profession of faith?

Does what happens Monday through Saturday agree with what you sing on Sunday?

Because:

"Can two walk together, except they be agreed?" — Amos 3:3

Amos is ultimately the voice of a God saying:

"I want you walking with Me—not merely worshiping near Me."

Hosea (c. 755–715 BC)

- Ministered during Israel's final decades.
- His marriage illustrated Israel's spiritual adultery.
- Continued preaching almost until Samaria fell.
- **Written before and possibly during the final years leading up to the Assyrian conquest (722 BC).**

Hosea was a contemporary of Amos... Both prophesied to the northern kingdom of Israel.

Hosea is often called “the prophet of Israel’s zero hour.”...

Israel had degenerated into such spiritual depravity that God’s judgment could no longer be delayed.

2 Kings 15–17 covers the period of Hosea and records the terrible sins of idol worship and unbridled sex in that time.

THE CENTRAL MESSAGE:

Return to the Lord... Hosea6:1

The word return occurs 15 times in Hosea.

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BOOK

Hosea—His marriage—compared to God and Israel —Chapters 1-3...and analogy.

Sin, judgement and ultimate blessing of Israel — chapters 4-14

Hosea: The Prophet Who Lived God's Broken Heart

Hosea's life was not merely the background to his message—it was his message.

More than any other prophet, Hosea was called to **live out** the relationship between God and Israel through his own marriage.

Hosea is one of the most emotionally moving books in Scripture because it reveals **the heart of God** rather than simply the judgment of God. Through Hosea's pain, God allows us to glimpse His own grief over Israel's spiritual adultery.

While Amos primarily exposed Israel's injustice, Hosea exposed **Israel's unfaithfulness**. Amos sounds like a prosecutor presenting evidence in court. Hosea sounds like a heartbroken husband pleading with the wife he still loves.

Hosea is not primarily about an unfaithful wife—it is about a faithful God.

The Historical Setting

Hosea ministered during one of the most unstable periods in Israel's history.

His ministry stretched approximately **40 to 50 years (around 755–710 BC)** during the reigns of:

Judah

- Uzziah

- Jotham
- Ahaz
- Hezekiah

Israel

- Jeroboam II

Research shows Hosea began prophesying near the end of Jeroboam II's prosperous reign and continued through Israel's rapid decline until shortly before the Assyrian conquest in **722 BC**.

Hosea watched the Northern Kingdom slowly collapse from within.

After Jeroboam II died:

- six kings ruled within about thirty years.
- four were assassinated.
- political chaos exploded.
- Assyria grew stronger.
- Israel continued refusing to repent.

The nation was falling apart politically because it had already fallen apart spiritually.

God's Shocking Command

The book begins with one of the most surprising commands in Scripture.

God told Hosea:

"Go, take yourself a wife of harlotry."

This command has generated much discussion.

Research shows several interpretations exist:

- Gomer was already living an immoral lifestyle.
- Gomer later became unfaithful after marriage.
- The wording may anticipate what she would become.

Regardless of which interpretation one adopts, the theological point remains the same:

Hosea's marriage became a living picture of God's covenant with Israel.

Just as Hosea genuinely loved Gomer despite her repeated betrayal, God genuinely loved Israel despite her continual spiritual adultery.

Gomer Represents Israel

Throughout Hosea,

Gomer repeatedly leaves her husband.

She pursues other lovers.

She believes they provide her:

- food
- clothing
- wine
- oil
- prosperity

Research shows this mirrors Israel's worship of Baal.

The Israelites believed Baal provided:

- rain
- crops
- fertility
- prosperity
- military success

Israel had not completely abandoned God.

Instead,

they attempted to worship both Yahweh and Baal simultaneously.

This mixture became spiritual adultery.

God desired covenant faithfulness,

not divided loyalty.

The Three Children

God instructed Hosea to give symbolic names to his children.

Each name became a prophecy. The children were named to symbolize judgment.

Jezreel—means God scatters.

Jezreel reminded Israel that God would soon judge the house of Jehu.

The valley of Jezreel had witnessed both Jehu's divinely authorized judgment and later generations' abuse of violence.

God declared that Israel's kingdom would soon end.

Lo-Ruhamah—means “not obtained mercy”

Meaning:

"No Mercy"

Research shows this signified that the Northern Kingdom had exhausted God's patience.

Judgment was approaching.

Yet even here God promised continued mercy toward Judah for a time.

Lo-Ammi—Means “Not my people”

Meaning:

"Not My People"

This may be the most devastating name of all.

It echoes the covenant formula:

"I will be your God,

and you shall be My people."

Now God declared:

"You are not My people."

This was covenant language.

Israel had so persistently broken the covenant that they were experiencing its legal consequences.

Yet God immediately followed with future promises of restoration.

Even covenant discipline was never God's final word.

In Hosea 1:2-9, God named Hosea's children Jezreel, Lo-Ammi and Lo-Ruhamah...look at the meaning of their names:

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Jezreel means “scattered by God.”

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Lo-Ammi Low ah me...means “not my people,”

-

and Lo-Ruhamah Low...rue..ha..mah... means “not loved.”

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Their names speak of condemnation, utter hopelessness & lostness.

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But because of the wondrous and unconditional love of God for His people, he commanded them to be renamed.

GOD REMOVES THE "NOT"

One of the most beautiful movements in Hosea occurs when God reverses these names.

The Hebrew word **Lo** means "**not**."

Therefore:

Lo-Ruhamah = **Not** shown mercy.

Lo-Ammi = **Not** My people.

But God's unconditional covenant love would not allow Israel's story to end with "**not.**"

In **Hosea 2:21–23**, God announces restoration.

The judgment names begin to be reversed:

"Not shown mercy" → shown mercy.

"Not My People" → "You are My people."

And the people respond:

"You are my God!"

What judgment had placed a "**not**" in front of, God's mercy promised to restore.

Hosea's love illustrates this beautifully:

Love removed the "not."

From Judgment to Identity

Hosea 2 describes an incredible reversal.

God promises that the heavens will respond.

The earth will respond.

The grain, wine, and oil will respond.

And **Jezreel**, whose name carried the picture of scattering, takes on the beautiful idea of **God planting or sowing again.**

The Voice captures the picture:

"I'll sow into My beloved land and plant the people in the land and make them My own."

The people who had been **scattered** would be **planted.**

The one who had received **no mercy** would receive **mercy.**

Those called **"Not My People"** would hear God declare:

"You are now My People!"

And they would answer:

"You're my God!"

This is more than changing a name.

God was changing a relationship and restoring an identity.

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Hosea 2:21-23...NET...

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"At that time,^[a] I will willingly respond,"^[b] declares the Lord.

"I will respond to the sky,
and the sky^[c] will respond to the ground;

22

then the ground will respond to the grain, the new wine, and the
olive oil;

and they will respond to 'God Plants' (Jezreel)!^[d]

23

Then I will plant her as my own^[e] in the land.

I will have pity on 'No Pity' (Lo-Ruhamah).

I will say to 'Not My People' (Lo-Ammi), 'You are my people!'

And he^[f] will say, 'You are^[g] my God!'"

The Voice

21

And I swear that when that day comes

I'll answer the sky and *prayers for rain*,

and the sky will give the land *the water* it's asking for.

22

And the land will give the grain and wine and oil *the fertile soil they need to develop*,

and the crops will shout back *to Me*, "God sows!"^[a]

23

I won't just restore the agricultural abundance;

I'll sow *into My beloved land* and plant the people in the land and make them My own.

To the one who has not been shown mercy,^[b]

I'll rename her Mercy.

I'll tell Not My People,^[c] "You are *now* My People!"

and he'll respond, "*You're my God!*"^[d]

"In that day I will respond...and the skies, earth, grain, new wine & olive oil will respond to Jezreel...

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I will show my love to the one I called "not my loved one"...

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I will say to those called, 'Not my people, You are my people; and they will say, "You are my God."'"

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This story reminds me of the song, “Reckless Love Of God.”

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There's no shadow You won't light up....Mountain You won't climb up.
Coming after me...

There's no wall You won't kick down...Lie You won't tear down coming after me.

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I am not deserving of God's amazing Grace, yet He loved me, redeemed me, justified me, saved me, rescued me, gave me life, adopted me, chased me down, fought til I was found, left the 99...

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God's love will not permit Him to give up on His people.

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Hosea may be home to one of the Bible's more unusual stories, but its message is one of the most important: Rescue is the constant pattern of God's activity.

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...I'm so glad He found me.



Hosea Redeems Gomer

Perhaps the most beautiful scene occurs later in the book.

Gomer has become enslaved.

She had descended into poverty and humiliation because of her sinful choices.

God instructed Hosea:

"Go again.

Love a woman who is loved by another."

Hosea purchased his own wife back.

He redeemed her.

Not because she deserved it.

Because he loved her.

This is one of Scripture's clearest Old Testament pictures of redemption.

The offended husband becomes the redeemer.

This beautifully foreshadows Christ,

who purchases His unfaithful Bride with His own blood.

Hosea's patience, compassion and his final acts of redeeming, chastening and restoring Gomer are the same qualities God will, and does, have for sinning Israel

Israel's Greatest Sin

Hosea repeatedly returns to one issue:

Israel no longer knew God.

One of the book's most famous verses declares:

"My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge."

Research shows the Hebrew word "know" means far more than intellectual information.

It describes intimate covenant relationship.

Israel still possessed religious ceremonies.

They still offered sacrifices.

But they had lost genuine relationship with God.

Religion had replaced intimacy.

Knowledge about God had replaced knowing God.

"I Desire Mercy, Not Sacrifice"

God declares:

"For I desire mercy and not sacrifice,
and the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."

Jesus later quoted this verse twice.

Research shows Hosea reveals God's priorities.

Sacrifices were never intended to replace obedience.

Worship without covenant faithfulness was empty.

God's desire has always been relationship before ritual.

The Valley of Achor

One of Hosea's most beautiful promises involves the Valley of Achor.

The Valley of Achor was where Achan's sin brought judgment upon Israel in Joshua 7.

Its name means:

"Trouble."

Yet God promises:

"I will make the Valley of Trouble a door of hope."

Research shows this reveals God's redemptive character.

The very place associated with failure becomes the place where hope begins.

Only God can transform places of judgment into places of restoration.

"I Will Betroth You Forever"

One of Hosea's greatest themes is covenant renewal.

God promises:

"I will betroth you to Me forever."

Notice the progression.

He does not merely forgive.

He restores the marriage.

Research shows the language intentionally recalls Israel's original covenant at Mount Sinai.

God was promising a future relationship built upon:

- righteousness
- justice
- lovingkindness
- compassion
- faithfulness

This ultimately points toward the New Covenant established through Jesus Christ.

Assyria Is Coming

Throughout Hosea,

God repeatedly warns that Assyria is coming.

Israel sought political alliances with:

- Assyria
- Egypt

instead of trusting God.

Note the tragic irony.

The nation Israel trusted for protection became the nation that conquered them.

In **722 BC**,

Assyria destroyed Samaria.

The Northern Kingdom ceased to exist as an independent nation.

Everything Hosea warned became reality.

Hope Beyond Judgment

Like Amos,

Hosea refuses to end with destruction.

Instead,

God declares:

"How can I give you up, Ephraim?"

These may be among the most emotional words God speaks anywhere in Scripture.

God's justice required judgment.

His love longed for restoration.

Research shows Hosea reveals the tension within God's covenant dealings.

He disciplines because He loves.

He wounds in order to heal.

He scatters in order to gather again.

Hosea allows readers to hear God's broken heart more clearly than almost any other prophetic book.

Hosea Compared with Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, and Amos

Elijah	Elisha	Jonah	Amos	Hosea
Confronted idolatry	Restored through miracles	Called Gentiles to repent	Exposed injustice	Revealed God's broken heart
Prophet during Ahab	Prophet across several kings	Prophet to Nineveh	Prophet to prosperous Israel	Prophet during Israel's final decline
Fire from heaven	Healing and provision	Mercy to enemies	Justice for the oppressed	Covenant love despite betrayal
Challenged Baal	Demonstrated compassion	Revealed mercy	Declared righteousness	Lived redemption through marriage

The Progression of God's Warnings

Notice how patient God was.

Through Elijah:

Return to the true God.

↓

Through Elisha:

Receive My mercy.

↓

Through Jonah:

Learn from a repenting pagan nation.

↓

Through Amos:

Your injustice is inviting judgment.

↓

Through Hosea:

My heart is broken, but I still love you.

↓

2 Kings 17:

The Assyrian captivity.

God's judgment did not come because He stopped loving Israel.

It came because Israel continually rejected His love.

NAME MEANINGS:

What Does the Name Hosea Mean?

Hosea — Hebrew: Hoshea (הוֹשֵׁעַ)

The name means:

“Salvation” or “Deliverance.”

Hosea/Hoshea comes from the Hebrew root associated with **salvation**.

Interestingly, it was also Joshua's original name before Moses changed it to **Yehoshua/Joshua**, incorporating the divine name and giving the sense **“Yahweh is salvation.”**

That makes Hosea's name remarkably appropriate for his life.

His marriage was a living sermon about a God who would **save, rescue, redeem and restore** an unfaithful people.

You could teach it simply:

Hosea's name means “Salvation.” His very name announced what God intended to do with an unfaithful people—save them.

What Does Gomer's Name Mean?

Gomer — Hebrew: Gomer (גֹּמֵר)

The Hebrew root is associated with:

“Complete,” “completion,” “finish,” or “bring to an end.” OR PERFECT.

The NET Bible's lexical material gives **“complete”** and connects the name with the Hebrew idea of finishing or completing something.

Hosea = Salvation

Gomer = Complete/Completion/Perfect

There Is a Beautiful Teaching Picture Here

Hosea — Salvation

pursues

Gomer — Completion

And Hosea doesn't merely find her.

He pays for her.

Hosea 3:2 tells us that he pays **15 shekels of silver and a quantity of barley** to bring the woman back.

Silver represents redemption...

Barley was associated with the poor and common people...

It was a less expensive grain than wheat.

Hosea paid 15 shekels of silver and a homer and

12 of barley...the payment itself reflected Homer's humiliated impoverished condition.

Hosea was paying to get back someone who was already His.

The woman he already loved became someone he had to **redeem**.

That's what makes the story so emotional.

She had been his.

She walked away.

Her choices brought her into bondage.

And then the man whose very name means **“Salvation”** was told by God:

Go again. Love her again.

He didn't merely stand at home waiting for her to find her way back.

He went after her.

And he didn't simply retrieve her.

He paid the price to redeem her.

That is exactly why Hosea becomes such a powerful living picture of God's relationship with Israel: **the betrayed One becomes the Redeemer of the one who betrayed Him.**

“After Gomer's unfaithfulness, God commanded Hosea to go again, love her again, and pay the price necessary to redeem her. Hosea's name means ‘Salvation,’ making his life a powerful picture of the God who pursues and redeems His unfaithful people.”

So the progression is powerful:

Gomer chased provision → lost her freedom → Hosea pursued her → Hosea paid for her → Hosea brought her home.

And Israel:

Chased other gods → lost her freedom → experienced exile → God pursued her → God promised redemption → God promised restoration.

How long did the Assyrian exile last:

Why Assyria?

God could have used any nation to judge Israel.

Why Assyria?

Assyria became **the rod of God's discipline** (compare Isaiah 10:5). God sovereignly used a ruthless empire to accomplish His covenant purposes, yet Assyria itself would later be judged for its arrogance.

Assyria was unlike previous conquerors.

Its military policy intentionally dismantled national identity.

When Assyria conquered a people, it would:

- Deport large portions of the population.
- Scatter them throughout the empire.
- Bring foreign peoples into the conquered land.
- Encourage intermarriage.
- Introduce foreign religions.

The goal was simple:

Destroy identity.

Without identity, rebellion became difficult.

Ironically, Israel had already been losing its spiritual identity long before Assyria removed its national identity.

The Assyrian Captivity

The Northern Kingdom finally fell in **722 BC** under King Hoshea.

2 Kings 17 gives the theological reason for the fall.

Notice what Scripture emphasizes.

Israel fell because they:

- Feared other gods.
- Worshiped idols.
- Rejected God's statutes.
- Ignored His prophets.
- Sacrificed their children.
- Practiced divination.
- Refused correction.
- Hardened their hearts.

The chapter almost reads like a courtroom verdict.

God carefully lists the evidence before announcing the sentence.

This chapter is one of the clearest demonstrations that **history is interpreted through covenant, not merely politics.**

The Assyrians did not defeat Israel because their army was stronger.

They defeated Israel because God removed His protective hand after centuries of covenant rebellion.

How Long Did the Assyrian Exile Last?

Unlike Judah, the Northern Kingdom never returned as a nation.

This is why people often refer to them as **the "Lost Ten Tribes."**

That phrase can be misleading.

The tribes were not "lost" to God.

They were scattered among the nations.

Many individuals from the northern tribes had already migrated into Judah during periods of revival, particularly under kings like Asa and Hezekiah (see 2 Chronicles 15:9; 30:1–11). Others were assimilated into the peoples of the Assyrian Empire.

There was **no national restoration of the Northern Kingdom** comparable to Judah's return from Babylon after about seventy years.

Yet the prophets consistently promised that God would one day regather all Israel. Christians differ on how these promises are fulfilled, but the prophetic hope of restoration remains a major biblical theme (e.g., Ezekiel 37; Hosea 1–3).

Summarizing Israel's history this way reminds us that **the covenant was relational before it was legal**. Israel's deepest sin was not simply breaking rules—it was abandoning the God who had redeemed them from Egypt.

God's judgments always serve His larger redemptive purpose. The prophets never end with destruction alone. They consistently point beyond exile to hope, restoration, and the faithfulness of God to His covenant promises.

The story of the Northern Kingdom is therefore not merely about a nation that fell. It is about a God who patiently pursued His people through prophet after prophet, warning after warning, miracle after miracle.

Even when Assyria carried Israel away, God's final word was not abandonment but the promise that one day He would gather His people again under the reign of the promised Son of David—the Messiah.

The Southern Kingdom of Judah

The Road to the Babylonian Captivity

A Bible Study Following the Story Through the Prophets

Theme: *God preserves His covenant even while He disciplines His people.*

If the story of the Northern Kingdom teaches us about **the certainty of God's judgment**, the story of the Southern Kingdom reveals **the certainty of God's covenant faithfulness**.

Unlike Israel, Judah had righteous kings mixed among wicked ones. There were seasons of revival, spiritual awakenings, and reforms that delayed judgment for more than a century after Israel fell. Yet Judah eventually committed many of the same sins as her northern sister. God patiently sent prophet after prophet, but the nation repeatedly hardened its heart.

Tom Bradford often says that **Judah had one advantage Israel never had—they possessed both the Temple and the Davidic king**. Yet those privileges became dangerous when the people began trusting the symbols instead of the God they represented.

Enduring Word points out that Judah's greatest temptation became **false security**. The people believed that because they had the Temple and the promises made to David, judgment could never happen. The prophets shattered that illusion by teaching that **God desires obedient hearts more than religious institutions**.

Why Judah Lasted Longer

The Northern Kingdom lasted about **209 years**.

Judah survived another **136 years**, lasting approximately **345 years** (931–586 BC).

Why?

Not because Judah was consistently more righteous.

Not because Jerusalem was unconquerable.

The primary reason was **God's covenant with David**.

Scripture says this plainly:

"Yet the LORD would not destroy Judah, for the sake of His servant David..."

2 Kings 8:19

Likewise,

"The LORD was not willing to destroy the house of David..."

2 Chronicles 21:7

Bradford emphasizes that this is one of the greatest demonstrations of God's covenant faithfulness in the Old Testament.

The kings failed.

The people failed.

The priests failed.

But God never failed.

The Davidic Covenant

Everything about Judah revolves around one promise.

In **2 Samuel 7**, God promised David:

- Your house will endure forever.
- Your kingdom will endure forever.
- Your throne will endure forever.

The Babylonian captivity appeared to destroy all three.

The royal family collapsed.

Jerusalem was destroyed.

The Temple burned.

The throne became vacant.

From a human perspective...

God's promise looked impossible.

Yet God was quietly preserving the royal line even in exile.

This becomes one of the great themes of 2 Kings.

Why Babylon?

Why didn't Assyria conquer Judah?

Why Babylon?

Isaiah had already prophesied that Babylon—not Assyria—would eventually carry Judah away (Isaiah 39:5–7).

Babylon became God's chosen instrument of discipline.

Unlike Assyria, whose strategy was to erase national identity through scattering populations, Babylon generally relocated conquered peoples together. This allowed communities such as the Jews to preserve their language, traditions, and Scriptures while living in exile.

Bradford notes that this difference was significant.

Babylon unknowingly preserved the nation God intended to restore.

The Babylonian Captivity

Babylon attacked Judah in stages.

First Deportation

605 BC

King Nebuchadnezzar defeated Judah.

Young nobles were taken captive.

Among them:

Daniel

Hananiah

Mishael

Azariah

Second Deportation

597 BC

King Jehoiachin surrendered.

Thousands more were deported.

Among them:

Ezekiel

Final Destruction

586 BC

Jerusalem fell.

The Temple burned.

The walls were destroyed.

King Zedekiah watched his sons executed before being blinded and taken to Babylon.

This fulfilled Jeremiah's prophecies with heartbreaking precision.

The nation that had ignored God's Word now experienced every covenant curse Moses had warned about centuries earlier (Deuteronomy 28).

How Long Did the Babylonian Exile Last?

Unlike Israel's exile...

Judah's captivity had an appointed ending.

Jeremiah repeatedly declared:

Seventy years.

This period fulfilled God's word (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10) and also allowed the land to enjoy the Sabbaths that Israel had neglected for generations (2 Chronicles 36:20–21).

Beginning in 538 BC, after the Persian king Cyrus conquered Babylon, Jewish exiles began returning to Judah under his decree.

Unlike the Northern Kingdom, Judah experienced a national return.

This restoration prepared the way for the coming of the Messiah centuries later.

The Prophets Who Spoke to Judah

Isaiah

Historical Setting

Isaiah ministered during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah.

He witnessed Assyria's rise while warning Judah not to repeat Israel's mistakes.

Main Message

Trust God.

Not political alliances.

Judah repeatedly looked to Egypt for protection.

Isaiah declared:

God is your Defender.

Trust Him alone.

One of Isaiah's greatest themes is:

The Holy One of Israel.

Everything begins with God's holiness.

Then Isaiah unfolds God's plan of redemption.

Isaiah's Greatest Contributions

He foretells:

- The virgin birth.
- The coming Messiah.
- The suffering servant.
- The Millennial Kingdom.
- The new heavens and new earth.

No prophet paints a more complete picture of Jesus.

Bradford often calls Isaiah "the Gospel of the Old Testament."

Micah

Micah preached during many of the same years as Isaiah.

Where Isaiah often addressed kings,

Micah spoke to ordinary people.

His major themes:

Justice.

Humility.

True worship.

He condemned:

- Corrupt leaders.
- Dishonest business.
- Religious hypocrisy.

Micah also delivered one of Scripture's clearest Messianic prophecies:

Bethlehem would become the birthplace of the Messiah.

(Micah 5:2)

Zephaniah

Zephaniah preached during King Josiah's reign.

Although Josiah brought revival,

Zephaniah warned that outward reform alone would not remove generations of sin.

His dominant theme:

The Day of the Lord.

God would judge Judah.

But after judgment...

God promised restoration.

Habakkuk

Habakkuk is unique.

Instead of speaking primarily to the people...

he questions God.

His first question:

Why do You allow evil in Judah?

God answers:

I'm raising up Babylon.

Habakkuk is shocked.

How can God use a nation even more wicked than Judah?

God's answer becomes one of the most quoted verses in Scripture:

"The righteous shall live by faith."

Habakkuk learns that faith trusts God's purposes even when His methods are difficult to understand.

Enduring Word highlights that Habakkuk moves from confusion to confident worship without receiving every answer he wanted.

Jeremiah

Jeremiah is often called:

The Weeping Prophet.

He ministered during Judah's final forty years before Jerusalem fell.

No prophet warned longer.

No prophet was rejected more.

Jeremiah preached:

Repent.

Submit to Babylon.

Judgment is certain.

False prophets promised peace.

Jeremiah announced surrender.

This made him appear unpatriotic.

But he was faithfully declaring God's Word.

Bradford emphasizes that Jeremiah understood something few others did:

Resistance to Babylon had become resistance to God's discipline.

One of Jeremiah's greatest contributions is the promise of the **New Covenant** (Jeremiah 31:31–34), where God promises to write His law on His people's hearts.

Nahum

Nahum's ministry is directed against Nineveh.

Years after Jonah's generation repented...

Assyria returned to violence and arrogance.

Nahum announces:

Nineveh's destruction.

God is patient.

But He is also just.

Assyria would now receive the judgment she once brought upon Israel.

Obadiah

Obadiah addresses the nation of Edom.

When Babylon destroyed Jerusalem,

Edom celebrated Judah's downfall.

Instead of helping their relatives,

they rejoiced over their suffering.

God judged Edom for pride, violence, and taking advantage of Judah's calamity.

One lesson stands out:

God notices how nations treat His people.

Joel

The exact date of Joel is debated, but many place him in relation to Judah's history.

Joel uses a devastating locust plague to illustrate:

The coming Day of the Lord.

Yet Joel also offers one of Scripture's greatest invitations:

"Return to Me with all your heart."

Joel ends with tremendous hope:

God promises to pour out His Spirit upon all flesh.

Peter quotes Joel 2 on the Day of Pentecost in Acts 2.

What Each Prophet Added to the Story

Prophet	Main Audience	Primary Emphasis	Connection to the Babylonian Captivity
Isaiah	Judah	Trust God, not nations	Warned Judah and revealed the coming Messiah and future Kingdom.
Micah	Judah	Justice, humility, Messiah	Exposed corruption and foretold Bethlehem as Messiah's birthplace.
Zephaniah	Judah	The Day of the Lord	Warned that judgment was near but restoration would follow.
Habakkuk	Judah	Living by faith	Explained why God would use Babylon as His instrument of discipline.
Jeremiah	Judah	Repentance and the New Covenant	Warned of the seventy-year exile and promised future restoration.
Nahum	Assyria	God's justice	Announced Nineveh's destruction after its return to wickedness.
Obadiah	Edom	Pride and accountability	Declared judgment on Edom for rejoicing over Judah's fall.
Joel	Judah	Repentance and the Spirit	Used disaster to call Judah back to God and pointed toward Pentecost.

The Progression of God's Warnings

Notice the increasing urgency.

Isaiah:

Trust God.

↓

Micah:

Practice justice and humility.

↓

Joel:

Return to Me with all your heart.

↓

Zephaniah:

The Day of the Lord is coming.

↓

Habakkuk:

Babylon is My instrument.

↓

Jeremiah:

Surrender, because judgment is now certain.

↓

2 Kings 25:

Jerusalem falls.

The Temple burns.

The people are taken to Babylon.

Why the Exile Was Different

The Babylonian captivity accomplished something remarkable.

During the exile:

- Idolatry largely disappeared from Jewish life.
- Synagogues began to develop as places of worship and teaching.
- The people developed a renewed devotion to the Scriptures.
- Greater emphasis was placed on preserving God's Word and covenant identity.
- Hope became centered on the coming Messiah rather than merely on an earthly kingdom.

Bradford notes that God used exile as a refining fire. Israel lost the land for a season, but she regained a deeper understanding that true covenant faithfulness begins with the heart.

The Great Lesson

The Southern Kingdom teaches that **God's discipline never cancels His promises.**

The Temple was destroyed.

The monarchy ended.

The people were exiled.

Yet God quietly preserved everything necessary for redemption.

The royal line of David survived.

The prophetic promises remained.

The hope of the Messiah endured.

Enduring Word beautifully observes that **2 Kings ends not with hopelessness but with a hint of grace**. The final chapter records King Jehoiachin being released from prison and honored in Babylon (2 Kings 25:27–30). That small act of mercy signals that the line of David is still alive. God's covenant has not failed.

The story of Judah, therefore, is not simply about the fall of Jerusalem. It is about the God who disciplines His people in order to restore them, who keeps every promise He has made, and who was preparing the world for the coming of David's greater Son—Jesus Christ, the eternal King who will one day sit upon David's throne and reign forever.

Timeline Summary

Time Period	Prophets
Before Assyria (Northern Kingdom)	Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, Amos, Hosea
Before Babylon (Southern Kingdom)	Isaiah, Micah, Joel (likely), Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Jeremiah (began here)
During Babylonian Captivity	Jeremiah (continued), Ezekiel, Daniel
Immediately After Jerusalem Fell	Obadiah (most likely)
After the Return from Exile	Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

One helpful way to teach this is to think of the prophets as God's voices at four key moments:

1. **Before the exile** — "Repent, or judgment is coming."
2. **During the exile** — "The judgment has come, but God has not abandoned you."
3. **After the exile** — "Return to the Lord, rebuild, and prepare for the coming Messiah."
4. **Throughout all three stages** — Jeremiah uniquely bridges the transition from warning, to witnessing the destruction, to ministering after Jerusalem's fall, making him the prophet who experienced nearly the entire Babylonian crisis firsthand.